

Newsletter layout with Scribus



Credit: DigiDio, Scribus

Scribus is a free desktop publishing application, with features suitable for printing and publishing.

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Scribus is a versatile and open source desktop publishing software, with really powerful, professional grade features and tools. The software is available under the Desktop Publishing section in this month's DVD. There are a number of templates, that can just be filled in with content, for a range of items including menus, brochures, newsletters and visiting cards. The packaging and installation guide shown above was created using Scribus. However, the user interface is a bit clunky, and might not be

so accessible to everyone. While there is a lot of freedom to design what you please, the software is not a very intuitive one, and is geared towards those who already have an experience in using other professional, paid desktop publishing tools. This workshop will take you on a step by step guide to creating your own newsletter, and show you how to use most of the features on the way.

STEP 1: PLAN OUT THE LAYOUT

Even before you start the software, it is important to decide how you want to present your content, and sketch out a layout for the newsletter. This means deciding the placement of

all the content, the space allocated to each news item, the placement of images, and the size of the headlines and so on. You can use MSPaint or actual pen and paper to figure this out. This step will help you figure out the settings for the project. You will have to also figure out how the newsletter will be printed. For example, if you want to use an A3 sized paper, fold it in half and have a four page newsletter. In this case, the first and last pages will be at different sides of the newsletter, but the second and third pages will be contiguous. For this example, we will be using a simple A4 sized newsletter, with content on only one side.

STEP 2: CHOOSE SETTINGS

Now, start up Scribus and create a New File. Under the "Number of Pages" field, select 1. Then go ahead and check the "Automatic Text Frames" box, and choose the "Columns" as "3". What this does is put a text box in the pages, with three columns each. This step makes the laying out easier, although you can manually do the same thing later on. The size should be A4, and orientation is portrait. Note the 11 point (pt) gap in the column width, this needs to be remembered for consistency later on. All the other settings are what is typically

